

UDL for Little Learners

Good teaching doesn't happen in a vacuum. It happens in schools where leaders create the conditions.

THREE QUESTIONS LEADERS ASK

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- 01** What do I need to understand to lead this?
 - 02** What should I look for in classrooms?
 - 03** How do I build a culture where UDL thrives?
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INTRODUCTION

A Note to Administrators

You picked up this book — or downloaded this guide — because you care deeply about the youngest learners in your building. That matters. A lot.

UDL for Little Learners was written for teachers. But good teaching doesn't happen in a vacuum. It happens in schools where leaders create the conditions that make it possible. This guide is for you: the director, the principal, the instructional coach, the curriculum coordinator who sets the tone, clears the path, and holds the vision.

THIS GUIDE IS ORGANIZED AROUND THREE BIG QUESTIONS LEADERS ASK

01 What do I need to understand about UDL to lead this work?

02 What should I be looking for when I visit classrooms?

03 How do I build a school culture where UDL can thrive?

How to Use This Guide

This guide is most powerful when used alongside the book. Each section references specific chapters so you can go deeper when you're ready. Read it through once to orient yourself, then keep the appendices close — they're built to be pulled out, copied, and used in real conversations.

What's Inside

PART 1 **Understanding UDL: The Leader's Foundation**

What you need to know before you lead

PART 2 **The Observation Framework**

What to look for in every UDL-aligned classroom

PART 3 **Leading the Learning**

Structures, conversations, and culture that make UDL stick

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One-page field tool for walkthroughs

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Explaining UDL to caregivers

PART 1

Understanding UDL: The Leader's Foundation

Before you can coach it, observe it, or celebrate it, you need to understand it. This section gives you the essential UDL fluency to lead this work with confidence.

The 30-Second Version

Universal Design for Learning is a proactive planning framework grounded in neuroscience. Instead of designing one lesson and then scrambling to accommodate learners who can't access it, UDL asks teachers to anticipate the predictable variability that walks into every classroom — and design flexible pathways from the start.

AFFECTIVE NETWORK Engagement <i>"Why should I care about this?"</i> Choice, relevance, challenge, autonomy	RECOGNITION NETWORK Representation <i>"What is the content?"</i> Visuals, audio, movement, varied formats	STRATEGIC NETWORK Action & Expression <i>"How do I show what I know?"</i> Drawing, talking, writing, building, performing
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"What's necessary for some is good for all."

Closed captions were designed for the hard of hearing. Ramps were designed for wheelchair users. Both turned out to be better for everyone. UDL is the ramp — build it in, and the whole school benefits.

The Three Core Beliefs

The book opens with three ideas that should anchor your leadership.

- 01

Variability is the rule, not the exception.
No two students experience the same classroom the same way. This isn’t a problem to solve — it’s a reality to design for.
- 02

All students can reach the same goals through flexible means.
UDL doesn’t lower the bar. It builds more pathways to the same destination.
- 03

All learners can develop agency and ownership — when barriers are removed.
Engagement isn’t magic. It’s the result of intentional design.

What UDL Is Not

Common misconceptions worth addressing directly with your staff.

WHAT PEOPLE THINK	WHAT IT ACTUALLY IS
A new curriculum to buy	A planning lens applied to what you already teach
Individualized plans for every student	Proactive design that works for the whole class
Only for students with disabilities	Beneficial for every learner — required for some
“Anything goes” / no structure	Flexible means toward firm, grade-level goals
More work for already-stretched teachers	Proactive planning that reduces reactive scrambling

Why Early Childhood, Why Now

31%

of fourth graders read at grade level nationally

AMONG THOSE PERFORMING FARTHEST BELOW

40% are Hispanic

1 / 4 are Black

1 / 3 have a disability

1 / 4 are English language learners

These gaps don't start in fourth grade — they *calcify* there. They start in your building.

Early childhood educators aren't downstream from the problem. You're at the beginning of the story. UDL gives your teachers a way to write a different one — before the gaps have a chance to harden.

WHY THIS IS AN EQUITY ISSUE

When we design only for the "average" student, we systematically disadvantage students of color, students with disabilities, English learners, and students from under-resourced homes. UDL is a core equity strategy — not an add-on.

PART 2

The Observation Framework

UDL is visible. When it's present in an early childhood classroom, you can see it, hear it, and feel it the moment you walk through the door. This section gives you a chapter-by-chapter lens so your walkthroughs become meaningful conversations — not compliance checks.

WALKTHROUGH MINDSET

The goal is not to evaluate whether a teacher is “doing UDL correctly.” It's to notice where barriers might still exist — and to wonder together about how to remove them.

Come curious, not critical.

The Environment

CHAPTER REFERENCE • DESIGNING THE ENVIRONMENT; COMMUNITY AND CONNECTIONS

The physical space is the first teacher. A well-designed UDL classroom tells students from the moment they walk in: *this place was made for you.*

LOOK FOR

Accessible materials. Supplies and resources labeled with images, not just words — and reachable without asking an adult.

Purposeful zones. A visible calm corner, a gathering area, collaborative table space, and options for working spread out or standing.

Flexible seating and student work displayed. Alternatives to a traditional chair, and a room that reflects the students in it — home languages, family structures, identities.

Visual schedules and accessible anchor charts. Students self-reference what comes next; charts are low enough to see, use images alongside words, and were built *with* students.

WONDER ABOUT

Which students are most dependent on the teacher to navigate this space? · Are there students with no obvious seating option that works for their body? · Does the room communicate high expectations, or does it feel like a place where only some children are expected to thrive?

Transitions

CHAPTER REFERENCE • TRANSITIONS

Transitions are one of the highest-leverage moments in the early childhood day — and one of the most overlooked. A UDL-aligned transition isn't just "managing" movement from one activity to the next. It's teaching the transition itself.

LOOK FOR

Multi-modal cues signaling a transition is coming — visual timer, sound signal, verbal countdown.

Choice within the transition. Students released by table, by choice, or by a signal that allows staggered movement.

Transition jobs that give students a role and reduce the chaos of open-ended "line up."

Pre-teaching. The teacher has explicitly taught what the transition looks and sounds like — it isn't assumed.

A landing structure at the destination. Students know exactly what to do when they arrive.

WONDER ABOUT

Which students are struggling most with transitions — and what might be driving that? • How much instructional time is spent *managing* transitions versus *teaching through* them?

Arrival and Morning Routines

CHAPTER REFERENCE • ARRIVAL AND MORNING ROUTINES

The first five minutes of the day set the tone for everything that follows. A UDL-informed arrival is predictable, warm, and immediately purposeful.

LOOK FOR

A consistent, **visual arrival routine** students can navigate independently — backpacks, folders, sign-in, morning work.

Personalized greeting. The teacher is at the door or accessible for brief connection with each child.

Engagement from the first moment. Students have something purposeful to do while others arrive — not just wait.

Embedded emotional check-in — visual mood meter, morning question, greeting ritual.

Morning Meeting

CHAPTER REFERENCE • MORNING MEETING

Morning meeting is one of the most authentically UDL structures in early childhood — when done well. It builds community, practices skills, and establishes belonging before instruction begins.

LOOK FOR

Multiple ways to participate — not just “raise your hand,” but turn-and-talk, gesture, draw, point.

The **greeting ritual is taught and practiced** — not just assumed.

A message or question that is **accessible to non-readers** — pictures, symbols, partner support.

All students have a genuine role. No one is invisible.

Small Group Instruction

CHAPTER REFERENCE • SMALL GROUP INSTRUCTION

Small group is where UDL’s power becomes most visible. When the teacher is meeting with a small group, the rest of the room should be productively humming — independently.

LOOK FOR

Students at stations working **independently without constant adult redirection.**

The small group table has **materials ready before the group arrives.**

Groupings are **flexible and purposeful** — not the same five kids always together.

Accountability structures exist for independent work — recording sheets, partner checks, anchor activities.

The teacher is **teaching**, not managing the rest of the room from the small group table.

WONDER ABOUT

How are groupings determined, and when were they last changed? • What happens when a student gets stuck during independent work — does the system hold?

Centers

CHAPTER REFERENCE • CENTERS

Centers are UDL in action — but only if they are designed with intention. A center that every student accesses the same way, at the same level, with the same materials isn't a UDL center. It's just a station.

LOOK FOR

Materials allow **multiple entry points** — a student early in their learning and one further along can both engage meaningfully.

Directions are visual and multimodal — a student who can't yet read can figure out the center independently.

Centers change with purpose. New materials are introduced with clear teaching, not just swapped in.

Student accountability without constant monitoring — recording sheets, partner roles, finished-work expectations.

Writing

CHAPTER REFERENCE • WRITING

Writing is one of the most complex things we ask early learners to do — it requires physical stamina, executive function, phonics knowledge, and vocabulary all at once. UDL-aligned writing instruction removes barriers without removing the goal.

LOOK FOR

A choice of tools. Pencils, crayons, markers, and paper options — lined, unlined, story boxes, different sizes.

Scaffolds available but not required. Alphabet charts, sound walls, word banks, sentence frames — accessible to all, mandated for none.

Students can **express ideas in multiple ways** — drawing first, talking before writing, dictating to a peer or tool.

The teacher's language **celebrates approximation** as the goal, not perfection.

A useful one-question test for any center or writing block: **if a student couldn't read a single word in this room, what would they do?**

Recess

CHAPTER REFERENCE • RECESS

Recess is rarely thought of as a UDL opportunity — but it is. As the administrator, you have more influence over recess than teachers do. The space, equipment, supervision model, and schedule are largely in your hands.

LOOK FOR

A **range of activities** — not just one ball, one game, one type of play.

Students with mobility, sensory, or social needs have **genuine access** to the playground experience.

Supervisors **facilitate, not just police** — they know names, notice isolation, support conflict resolution.

The transition back inside is **structured and taught**.

YOUR ROLE AS ADMINISTRATOR

Walk the space yourself during recess — observe who is included and who is on the margins.

Advocate for equipment and space improvements.

Train supervisors as intentionally as you train teachers.

Protect recess time — don't use it as a consequence or cut it to make room in the schedule.

Read Aloud & Whole Group Literacy

CHAPTER REFERENCE • READ ALOUD / WHOLE GROUP LITERACY

Students are invited to **respond in multiple ways** — gesture, talk, draw, think silently.

Turn-and-talk is a regular structure, and partnerships are purposefully designed.

The teacher **makes thinking visible** — models visualizing, wondering, connecting.

Books reflect a **diversity of characters, families, and experiences** — all students see themselves.

Closing Circle

CHAPTER REFERENCE • CLOSING CIRCLE AND DISMISSAL

A **consistent closing routine** students can predict and rely on.

Reflection embedded — students name something they learned, felt, or want to try tomorrow.

A **farewell ritual** that ends the day with warmth and connection.

Students **leave regulated** — not wound up, not rushed, not anxious.

— PART 3

Leading the Learning: Culture, Coaching & Systems

Knowing what UDL looks like isn't enough. Your job is to create the conditions under which teachers can actually do it — and keep doing it. This section is about the leadership moves that make UDL a school-wide practice, not a one-room wonder.

Start With Why — Every Time

Before introducing any new practice, connect it to the data that lives in your building. Which students are most often removed from the classroom? Which groups are showing the largest gaps in early literacy? Who is engaging — and who isn't?

UDL is not a program. It's a response to those numbers. When your team understands that, the resistance decreases and the motivation increases.

LEADERSHIP MOVE • LEAD WITH THE DATA

Pull your discipline data. Pull your referral data. Pull your early literacy screening data. Disaggregate it by race, disability status, and home language. Put those numbers in the room *before* you introduce the framework. Let the data ask the question UDL answers.

A Word on Resistance

Every staff has them: the teacher who has been doing this for twenty-two years and is deeply skeptical. The one who says, "I already do this." The one who is too exhausted to try one more thing.

The book tells the story of a first-grade teacher nearing the end of a long career who reluctantly tried a new writing strategy and later had to "eat crow" because it worked — then couldn't wait to try it again. That's the story you're looking for. You won't find it by mandating compliance. You'll find it by creating conditions where one small win becomes possible, then celebrating that win loudly.

The Implementation Sequence

The book's closing chapter says it plainly: don't try to universally design everything at once. Pick one thing. Get it running. Let success breed success. The same principle applies to your school-wide rollout.

PHASE	FOCUS	WHAT LEADERS DO
Awareness MONTH 1–2	Build shared vocabulary. Introduce the why. Connect to existing values.	Facilitate book study or article discussion. Share data. Visit a UDL classroom together.
One Part of the Day MONTH 2–4	Every teacher picks one routine to universally design — morning meeting, centers, transitions.	Use the look-fors in Part 2. Provide coaching conversations. Celebrate early wins publicly.
Environment Audit MONTH 3–5	Teams audit their physical spaces against UDL criteria.	Walk rooms together. Identify resource gaps. Solve for barriers at the system level.
Lesson Design MONTH 4+	Teachers begin using the “Predicting Barriers” protocol for lesson planning.	Embed the Predicting Barriers framework in PLC and planning structures.
Sustaining & Spreading YEAR 2+	UDL is the lens for all instructional coaching, evaluation, and new-teacher onboarding.	Integrate UDL language into your school improvement plan and teacher goal-setting process.

LEADERSHIP MOVE • FIND YOUR EARLY ADOPTERS

The antidote to resistance is not pressure — it's proximity to a success story. Find the teacher already doing elements of this work. Make their classroom the place everyone visits. Name what they're doing out loud. That's your fastest lever.

The Predicting Barriers Protocol

One of the book's most powerful tools for teachers is the habit of asking: *what barriers might my students face in this part of the day?* As a leader, you can embed this question into every planning and coaching structure you run. Teach your team to ask three questions before every lesson, routine, or activity.

01

Who might struggle to access this?

Sensory, language, attention, prior knowledge, physical.

02

What's the fix that helps everyone?

The UDL response — not a pull-out, not a modification for one child.

03

How will I know the barrier was removed?

What does success look like — and for whom?

TRY THIS IN YOUR NEXT PLC

Make "Predicting Barriers" a standing agenda item. Ask teams to bring one barrier they identified this week — and one solution they tried. Over time, this builds the muscle.

Coaching Conversations That Build UDL Thinking

Your post-observation conferences are one of your most powerful tools. Four questions that build UDL thinking without putting teachers on the defensive:

"Tell me about a student who surprised you today — in a good way."

Surfaces what worked, and for whom.

"Which part of the lesson would you do differently with more time to plan?"

Opens barrier-identification without evaluation pressure.

"If a student couldn't read any of the words in this room, what would they do?"

A fast, concrete test of accessibility.

"Who do you worry about most during [routine]? What's getting in the way?"

Builds the habit of attributing struggle to design, not deficit.

Systems That Sustain UDL

Individual teachers doing great things is not a school. Here's what needs to be true at the system level.

SYSTEM	UDL-ALIGNED PRACTICE
Hiring	Ask candidates: "Tell me about a time a lesson didn't work for a student. What did you change?" Look for asset-based language and a proactive planning mindset.
Onboarding	New teacher orientation includes a UDL overview, a classroom environment audit tool, and a walkthrough with a veteran peer within the first three weeks.
Professional Development	PD is itself universally designed — not just lecture. Teachers experience what their students experience.
Evaluation	Observation tools include UDL look-fors (see Appendix B). Teachers are recognized for proactive barrier prediction, not just reactive differentiation.
Family Engagement	Communication about UDL is multilingual, jargon-free, and assets-based. (See Appendix D for a template.)
Schedule Design	Recess is protected. Transitions have built-in buffer time. Specials scheduling supports — not undermines — predictable routines.

APPENDIX A

Pre-Observation Conversation Guide

Use these questions before a classroom visit to set the teacher up for success and frame the observation as a learning conversation — not an evaluation.

ABOUT THE STUDENTS

Who are you most excited about right now? What's working for them?

Who are you most worried about? What do you think is getting in their way?

Is there a student I should pay particular attention to during this visit?

ABOUT THE LESSON OR ROUTINE

Walk me through what I'll see. What's the goal for students?

What barriers did you anticipate when planning this?

What did you do to address those barriers in your design?

What would you want me to notice?

ABOUT THE ENVIRONMENT

Is there anything about the physical space you've changed recently or want to revisit?

How do students know what to do when they're stuck during independent work?

APPENDIX B

UDL Classroom Look-Fors

A one-page field tool for walkthroughs. Use it to spark conversation — not to score.

LOOK-FOR	NOTES
☐ Visual schedule posted and accessible to students	
☐ Materials and resources labeled with images + words	
☐ Flexible seating options available	
☐ Calm corner or regulation space present and accessible	
☐ Students can navigate the space independently	
☐ Multiple ways to participate are offered (not just hand-raising)	
☐ Anchor charts built with students and accessible to them	
☐ Choice is embedded in at least one part of the lesson or routine	
☐ Writing tools and scaffolds are available as a buffet	
☐ Turn-and-talk or partner structures are in use	
☐ Transitions have a clear signal, expectation, and landing structure	
☐ Small group work is happening; others are productively independent	
☐ Closing circle or reflection structure is present	
☐ All students appear to have a genuine role or point of entry	

AFTER THE VISIT, CONSIDER

What did you see that you want to celebrate specifically and publicly? · Where did a student struggle to access something — and what was the barrier? · What one question will you bring to the teacher in your debrief?

APPENDIX C

Professional Learning Menu

A suggested sequence for building UDL capacity across a school year. Adapt based on where your staff is starting.

WHEN	LEARNING FOCUS	SUGGESTED STRUCTURE	BOOK CONNECTION
Aug / Sept	What is UDL? Why does it matter here?	Two-hour launch session; data share; staff discussion	Overview; What is UDL?
October	Environment audit: does our space work for all learners?	Team room walks; environment redesign work session	Designing the Environment
November	Building community intentionally	PLC protocol; share morning meeting structures	Community & Connections; Morning Meeting
Dec / Jan	Centers and independent work that actually works	Lab classroom visit; center design workshop	Centers; Small Group Instruction
February	Writing as a UDL moment	Student work protocol; try-it lesson	Writing
March	Transitions and the day as a whole	Map a full day together; identify transition friction points	Transitions; Arrival; Closing Circle
Apr / May	Reflection: where do we go from here?	Year-end showcase; set goals for next year	Reflection; Where to Go From Here

APPENDIX D

Family Communication Template

Use and adapt this template to introduce UDL to families in plain, jargon-free language. Translate as needed.

Dear Families,

At [School Name], we believe every child deserves to feel capable, curious, and connected at school — from the very first day. That’s why we’re excited to share an approach our teachers use called **Universal Design for Learning**, or UDL.

What does UDL mean for your child?

It means we design our classrooms, lessons, and routines so that every student has a genuine way to participate and succeed — not just the students who already “fit” the traditional school mold.

HERE’S WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN ACTION

Your child may have choices about where to sit, what tools to use, or how to share what they know.

Our classrooms have calm corners — quiet spaces students can visit when they need to reset.

We teach routines explicitly, so students know what to do without having to constantly ask an adult.

We use pictures and visuals alongside words so all learners can navigate the day independently.

Why does this matter?

Research shows that children learn best when they feel safe, engaged, and like they belong. We also know that the way school is traditionally designed doesn’t work equally well for all children — especially children of color, children with disabilities, and children who are learning English. UDL is one of the ways we’re working to change that.

We’d love to hear from you.

If you ever have questions about what your child is experiencing at school, or if you’d like to visit to see UDL in action, please reach out. Your partnership makes everything we do more powerful.

Warmly,

[Principal / Director Name]

[School Name]

Reminder: professional translators are always preferable to machine translation for family-facing documents. Many districts have language access coordinators who can support this process.

You Are the Beginning of the Story

The closing lines of *UDL for Little Learners* speak directly to teachers. But they apply equally to you.

“You are the beginning of the story of school for your kiddos. Create a place where there are multiple entry points, where everyone belongs, where they LOVE coming to school — and set a foundation for the rest of their schooling.”

FROM *UDL FOR LITTLE LEARNERS*

As an administrator, your influence extends across every classroom, every morning, every recess, and every family that walks through your door. The teachers in your building will implement UDL with the courage and consistency that matches the culture you create.

That culture starts with you believing — truly believing — that every child who walks into your building deserves a school designed for them. Not retrofitted for them.

Designed for them, from the start.

This book gives your teachers the how. You give them the why, the support, and the space to try. That combination is unstoppable.

UDL for Little Learners by Jeff Horwitz

PUBLISHED BY WILEY • DECEMBER 2026 • FOREWORD BY KATIE NOVAK

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